DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Every Morning a New Creation: The Blessings of Shema

Derech Hashem 4:4:11-12

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 4, Chapter 4, paragraphs 11-12 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Thursday 24 February 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Where we are in Part 4

The Rabbi set the context. Part 4 divides the misvot into what we do and what we study. The misvot we do are divided into four kinds: daily, periodic (like Shabbat and festivals), circumstantial, and constant (like the love and fear of God). Shema is the first of the daily misvot.

So far the chapter has covered the first verse, Barukh Shem, mesirut nefesh, the three paragraphs and the 248 words, which correspond to the 248 parts of the body: "we're enveloping ourselves, our entire body, every morning and evening with Yihud Hashem." What remains is the blessings of Shema.

Two questions from the group

A participant asked: if leaving Egypt completed the cleansing from the sin of Adam, how could the golden calf bring it back? Was it not a new sin? The Rabbi called it a good point and offered an analogy. If someone wrongs me and I forgive him completely, and then he does something else, that shows retroactively that the reconciliation was not real. I did forgive at the time, but I can see it was not sincere. So the new sin traces back to the old one.

Another participant shared that he had learned from Rav Mandel that the first paragraph of Shema is aimed more at the individual, a high theological concept of accepting God's oneness, while the second is addressed to the people in general.

Every morning a renewal

Everything until now is from the Torah. The blessings around Shema were added by Hazal. In the morning there are two before and one after; in the evening two before and two after. Why the difference, and why are the morning blessings so much longer?

The Ramhal answers that every morning creation is renewed. The Rabbi raised the obvious difficulty: have we not learned that God renews the world every moment? He recalled his analogy from the beginning of the series: if you create a universe in your mind and stop to

answer the phone, the universe is gone. So yes, God maintains the world every second. Yet there is also a particular renewal every morning. "If someone is ill, what's the best medicine? A good night's sleep." There is something about the morning that renews life.

A participant suggested that the world's soul is taken away at night and restored, like a person's. The Rabbi said that is not what is meant; rather, the morning is a new start.

The Ramhal describes this renewal from two perspectives:

1. Preservation: the energy that maintains the world all day is given "a new bang" each morning.
2. Each day's own light: every single day from the beginning of the six thousand years has its own illumination and influence, prepared to bring the world to its final point. "Every single day is a new creation."

From the second point the Rabbi drew a practical lesson. A missed day can never be made up. Rosh Hashanah of one year is a different Rosh Hashanah from the next. "You miss a day, it's gone forever. That unique energy for that day will never come back again."

The morning blessings

Creation can be divided into two parts: humanity, whose pinnacle is the Jewish people (as learned in Part 2), and everything else, the angels, the heavenly bodies and nature below.

- The first blessing praises God for all of creation apart from humanity: the light, the sun and moon, the creatures, and the angels and what they say.
- The second blessing is about the Jewish people: God's love for us, that He brought us near to His service, chose us and gave us the Torah.
- After Shema, the third blessing is for the miracles God performed for us, chiefly the Exodus and the sea, but also all the times He stood up for us.

As the Rabbi had mentioned before, the main tefillah really begins with the blessings of Shema.

The evening blessings and Hashkivenu (paragraph 12)

The main renewal is in the morning. At the beginning of the night there is a small addition, like a completion of the light of the day. So Hazal also instituted blessings in the evening, but much shorter, because they only repeat the morning and because the renewal itself is minute.

The outline is the same: the first evening blessing speaks of creation, the stars and the order of the heavens; the second of Israel, our relationship with God and the Torah; the third again refers to the Exodus. The fourth, Hashkivenu, is added because we are going to sleep: let us sleep in peace, and be kept from illness and sorrow.

This is why the halachah is to say Shema and its blessings at the beginning of the morning and the beginning of the evening. The Rabbi was critical of saying Arvit at eleven at night in winter when night fell at four, or saying the morning blessings at a quarter to ten on Shabbat, hours after sunrise. "Start the day, start the evening."

Does the day start at night?

A participant asked: if the evening is only a completion of the morning, why does our day begin at night? The Rabbi called it an excellent question. In halachah the day starts at night for dating and counting, because the world was created night first. But human beings are programmed to sleep at night and be renewed in the morning. That is why the Shulhan Arukh, which follows the misvot as they meet a person, begins with getting up in the morning, then sisit, tefillin, blessings, Shema, prayer, eating, Birkat HaMazon, Minhah and Arvit. He added that he could not imagine a life of working through the night: "I think it's against human nature."

A further question asked why the renewal shifted from night, when the world was created, to morning. The Rabbi discussed when Adam was created on the sixth day, suggesting the morning, with time needed for naming the animals and the creation of Havah before the sin that afternoon. Why God created night before day he did not know. Perhaps darkness before light. And he added that we do not know what existed before Bereshit, the beginning of this universe: "Who knows what God's doing? All we know is our little universe."

This completes Shema. The next class begins the chapter on Tefillah.

Summary

- The blessings of Shema were instituted by Hazal because creation is renewed every morning.
- Beyond constant maintenance, each day has its own unique light; a missed day never returns.
- Morning: the first blessing praises God for creation, the second for His love of Israel, the third for the miracles of the Exodus.
- Evening blessings follow the same outline but are short, since the night only completes the day; Hashkivenu asks for peaceful sleep.
- Shema should be said at the start of the morning and the start of the evening, when the renewal happens.

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